narrated in the last chapter—was cited as an illustration. Ashe adduced the interested evidence of the BI manager Varaprasadam Pillai to prove his case. It was argued that Kaithan Villavarayar, BI's boat contractor, was at first prevented from entering the house by VOC's men. While questioning M.N. Gonsalves, in whose house the meeting was held, Ashe tried to push him into testifying that VOC issued threats to win custom.[24] Though K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, who appeared as the defence vakil, objected to the drift of the questions, it was to no avail.[25] Guruswami Aiyar's writ to transfer the case to another court was dismissed by the high court.[26] Luckily, the case fell through when Ashe was transferred out of the district and his successor found no clinching evidence to extract security.[27] In any case, Ashe failed to silence the vakils. At least two of them—K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and P.L. Vengu Aiyar—continued to serve SSNCo with dedication.

Ashe's brazen intimidation is further borne out by a notorious incident. On 21 March, Ashe went to the registered office of SSNCo, accompanied by the Ceylon quarantine medical officer, Dr Van Langenberg. Quoting chapter and verse from the Indian Companies Act, 1882, he produced a rupee and demanded inspection of some company documents including the share register. Most of the staff had already left since it was late in the afternoon on a Saturday. The only employee present, a lowly clerk named Kandaswamy Pillai, trembling in fear in the presence of the town's most important *durai* (white sahib), dithered. Ashe reprimanded him stating that his refusal to produce the documents was illegal and called Dr Van Langenberg to bear witness—the choice of a person of official standing to accompany him was evidently not a coincidence. Soon after this drama, Ashe was seen talking to Newton, the BI's agent.[28] The blatantly partisan intervention of Ashe was widely reported. A correspondent of *The Hindu* described Ashe's tilting at the Swadeshi mills as 'his memorable expedition … and his splendid retreat'.[29] That this is no exaggeration of the nationalist press is borne out by K.R. Guruswami Aiyar's letter—in his capacity as SSNCo's honorary legal adviser—of 23 March 1908 to Ashe.